

Boundaries and consequences

A predictable structure allows children to focus on fun and enjoyment rather than being unsure what rules they might unknowingly break. It also prevents becoming focused on fairness and structure with friends or at school, because their home life has a healthy framework.

When a child's boundaries are disrespected, they are unlikely to grow up with healthy boundaries themselves. Their boundaries will either be too loose or too rigid, so try to avoid:

- Tickling a child after he or she has told you to stop. (Teach your child that he or she has a right to say no.)
- Pushing physical affection on a child. (Teaching your child to say no to unwanted affection begins with you.)
- Denying a child's feelings. ("You aren't scared, tired, thirsty...")
- Telling a child that they should not feel a particular way. (Your child can feel the way they feel but may not be allowed to act out on that feeling.)
- Discounting a child's opinions. (You can acknowledge their opinion even if you do not agree with it.)

Define your boundaries

To develop boundaries for yourself, you need to take time to work out what you value, and what your non-negotiables are. This is not always easy to define, but it is so important that your child knows who you are and what you believe. This does not mean you should be rigid; it means you communicate your personal values and stick to them. If your value is to be honest, for example, then talk it and walk it. Children are watching what you do – this makes more of an impression than what you say.

Let your child experience the impact of a crossed boundary

Help your children experience the impact of crossing boundaries so that it becomes part of their reality. Apologise when you have crossed someone else's boundary. When your children cross one hold them accountable. For example, if you promise your child that you will drive them to the cinema after they do their chores and they play video games instead, then following through (by not driving them) lets your child experience the consequences and will come to understand on a deep level what you expect. They will know that you respect yourself and mean what you say. Eventually, they will learn good boundaries for themselves and how to respect others as well.

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- B** oost self- esteem and teach children morals.
- O** ffer opportunities to test and find limits.
- U** nderpin children with safety and security.
- N** ormalise being able to say "no" and respecting ourselves.
- D** efine what is acceptable.
- A** cknowledge that everyone has the right to our own beliefs.
- R** einforce what we need to feel comfortable and safe.
- I** mpart our needs, wants and expectations.
- E** nable our child/ren to stand up for themselves and others.
- S** upply a reference for what is reasonable & what our values are.

Boundaries and Consequences

What to do when boundaries are crossed?

Children will always want to push the boundaries – how we handle this is as important as setting them in the first place. We want to teach our children to make good decisions, in a loving and supportive way. So, we need to be clear about the consequences of our children's actions and choices right from the start.

- Make consequences age appropriate.
- Be sure you can live with the consequences you set up.
- Make consequences immediate.
- Use consequences that are short and to the point.
- Make them logical and fair.

Writing the rules as a family gives everyone a voice but the parents are in charge and have the final say. It is good to be prepared before the meeting and have some rules in your mind – talk this through with your partner or someone who helps you with your children regularly. A united approach stops children playing one parent off against the other.

Please note that all members of the family are accountable – they are family rules that apply to everyone.

Natural consequences

A natural consequence is anything that happens naturally. When you stand in the rain, you get wet. When you do not eat, you get hungry. When you forget your coat, you get cold.

Children usually feel guilty if they make a mistake. Show empathy and understanding for what the child is experiencing: "I'll bet it was hard to go hungry (get wet, get that bad grade, lose your bicycle)." When it seems appropriate, you could add, "I love you and know you can sort this out." Try not to rescue or overprotect but help your children develop a sense of capability.

Logical consequences

Even though natural consequences often help children learn responsibility, there are times when natural consequences are not practical, such as:

When a child is in danger.

e.g. We cannot let our children suffer the natural consequences of running into the road without looking.

When natural consequences interfere with the rights of others.

e.g. We cannot allow our child to throw heavy things at another person

When the results are not important to them, but the natural consequences will affect their health and well-being.

e.g. it may not seem like a problem to some children if they do not bathe or shower, brush their teeth, or eat a vast amount of junk food.

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Logical consequences must be:

Related - means the consequence must be related to the behaviour.

Respectful - no blame, shame, or pain and be kindly but firmly enforced being respectful to everyone involved.

Reasonable - means the consequence must be reasonable from the child's point of view as well as the adults.

Helpful - means it will encourage change for everyone involved.

Consequences

- C** onsequences occur naturally and logical ones are applied.
- O** nly step in when a logical consequence is necessary.
- N** egative consequences mean less likely to repeat.
- S** hort and to the point consequences give a clear message.
- E** nsure consequences are age/stage appropriate.
- Q** uietly state the consequence and stick to it – no need to shout!
- U** nderstand and show empathy for natural consequences.
- E** nsure you give positive attention for positive behaviours.
- N** eed to make them related, respectful, reasonable, and helpful.
- C** reate time for family meetings to discuss consequences.
- E** nable your child to feel the impact of a crossed boundary.
- S** uffering can lead to resentment, revenge, rebelling, or retreating.